Oliver Herbert

CELLIST · BIOGRAPHY

Oliver Herbert is a cellist who performs as a soloist, as a chamber musician, and in programs of his own. The recipient of a 2021 Avery Fisher Career Grant, he has appeared as soloist with the San Francisco Symphony, Nashville Symphony, New World Symphony, Buffalo Philharmonic, and Warsaw Philharmonic, as well as the Mannheimer Philharmoniker, Württembergisches Kammerorchester Heilbronn, and Philharmonisches Orchester Erfurt. He has worked with conductors including Michael Tilson Thomas, Giancarlo Guerrero, Juanjo Mena, Teddy Abrams, Alexander Shelley, and Reinhard Goebel. Of his subscription debut with the San Francisco Symphony under Tilson Thomas, San Francisco Classical Voice wrote: “His technical command, full-throated but never indulgent tone, crisp yet expressive phrasing, and tactful use of vibrato flowed together… youthful but magisterial.”

Oliver approaches his work with a wide-ranging curiosity, exploring lesser-known repertoire, music of today, and connections that reveal new perspectives on familiar works. He has performed complete cycles of the Bach suites and Beethoven sonatas, the latter also on historical instruments with Arash Rokni, and the music of Paul Desenne has become an ongoing focus. His projects have included concert curations for Deutschlandfunk’s Raderbergkonzerte and the TICA Festival in Hong Kong, as well as premieres of works by composers such as Andrew Moses, Žibuoklė Martinaitytė, and Helena Winkelman, among them Moses’ Ecstatic Immanence, which he commissioned.

His interdisciplinary work includes Druck (Pressure), a program about power that set music alongside literary texts and silent film scenes prepared with filmmaker Mimi Pfahler, with whom he had earlier made a video of Janáček’s Pohádka. For the 2026 Kronberg Festival he curated a program on the theme of courage with actor Michael Rotschopf. At New World Symphony, he performed Julius Eastman’s The Holy Presence of Joan d’Arc with Kyle Marshall Choreography.

As a chamber musician, he returns regularly to ChamberFest Cleveland, Marlboro Music, Caramoor, and the St. Barts Music Festival. He has also appeared at the Schwetzinger SWR Festspiele, Moritzburg Festival, Rheingau Musik Festival, Ravinia, La Jolla SummerFest, and Philadelphia Chamber Music Society. Recent highlights include a North American tour with Mitsuko Uchida and musicians from Marlboro Music, a return to Carnegie Hall with Kirill Gerstein, and a performance at the Tonhalle Zürich with Julia Fischer. Other collaborators include Janine Jansen, Tabea Zimmermann, and Martin Helmchen.

Oliver’s recordings include Haydn’s Cello Concerto in D major with the San Francisco Symphony and Michael Tilson Thomas, released by Warner Classics as part of highlights from Tilson Thomas’s final season as music director. His debut album with pianist Xiaohui

Yang, Frame of Mind (2020), pairs the two cello sonatas of Gabriel Fauré with Leoš Janáček's Pohádka (Fairy Tale). In 2026 the Mannheimer Philharmoniker released his recording of Beethoven's Triple Concerto with violinist Dora Bratchkova, pianist Olga Zado, and conductor Boian Videnoff. He has been featured on PBS's Now Hear This, NPR's From the Top, WQXR, and German radio including WDR, Deutschlandfunk, HR, and ARD.

His honors include the Verbier Festival's Jean-Nicolas Firmenich Prize, first prize at the Irving M. Klein International String Competition, and prizes at the Lutosławski International Cello Competition and the Stulberg International String Competition. He received Kronberg Academy's Marcus-Dieter-Neubronner-Förderpreis in 2023, and in 2025 was selected for the Orpheum Foundation's development program for young soloists. Also active as a teacher, he has given masterclasses at Brown University, Hong Kong University and the San Francisco Conservatory of Music, and has mentored young chamber musicians at the YARO Exzellenz Forum in Rostock and the Janigro Festival.

Born into a family of musicians in San Francisco, he studied with Clive Greensmith at the Colburn School and with Carter Brey, Pamela Frank, and Peter Wiley at the Curtis Institute of Music. As a Curtis student, he was invited through open audition to perform Strauss's Don Quixote on the Chicago Symphony Orchestra's Family Matinee Series. That season he also performed it with the Curtis Symphony Orchestra, and the Philadelphia Inquirer praised the "deeply moving vocal inflections" of his playing. He continued his studies with Frans Helmerson at Kronberg Academy, supported by the Nanno Lenz Patronage. He plays a Guadagnini cello that once belonged to the Italian cellist Antonio Janigro, on loan from the Janigro family.

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